THE SHIFTING WIND IN MALE

Indian aid and support for the Maldives have marked close ties between the two nations. But newly elected, pro-China president Mohamed Muizzu's 'India Out' campaign and demand for the withdrawal of Indian personnel have New Delhi worried

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

Within minutes of the Maldivian state broadcaster declaring Mohamed Muizzu as the president-elect on October 1, Prime Minister Narendra Modi was the "first leader" to congratulate him. In his message, PM Modi said that India remains committed to strengthening the time-tested India-Maldives bilateral relationship and enhancing "our overall cooperation in the Indian Ocean Region". However, the latest development poses a problem for India—the pro-China Muizzu, from the People's National Congress party, won power in the island-nation on an 'India Out' campaign, raising fears of the Maldives emerging as a pit stop in China's 'String of Pearls' scheme of military and commercial establishments in the region. Indeed, soon after attending the national day celebrations of China at its embassy in Male on October 8, Muizzu declared, "Maldivians do not want any foreign troops to be present in the country, be it from India or any other country." However, he emphasised that military cooperation with India will continue. PM Modi was the only major head of state to attend the pro-India Ibrahim Mohamed Solih's swearing-in ceremony in November 2018. This year, with the anti-India election plank of Muizzu, India was represented by Union



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